Chapter Forty-Seven

The Shadow of God

Between 1236 and 1266,
the crown of Delhi passes from
the family of Iltumish to a Turkish slave
who becomes absolute monarch

THE SULTAN OF DELHI, Iltumish, was dead. His sons were "engrossed in the pleasures of youth," none of them worthy of the throne; and so Iltumish left his crown to his daughter Raziyya. "[She] was a great sovereign, and sagacious," the *Tabakat-i-Nasiri* tells us, "just, beneficent . . . and of warlike talent, and was endowed with all the admirable attributes and qualifications necessary for kings; but, as she did not attain the destiny, in her creation, of being computed among men, of what advantage were all these excellent qualifications to her?"[1]

Her father's officers divided. The vizier of Delhi and his supporters, hoping to put one of the sultan's useless sons on the throne instead, mounted an attack on the palace, while several governors from the outlying provinces marched with their forces to Delhi to fight for Raziyya. The queen's supporters won, driving the malcontents out of the city.

The opposition never fully faded, though. Raziyya appointed as Master of the Stables (a military position, directing the deployment of both horses and elephants) an African soldier named Malik Hakut, born in the highlands of the